



◀ GREAT ZIMBABWE

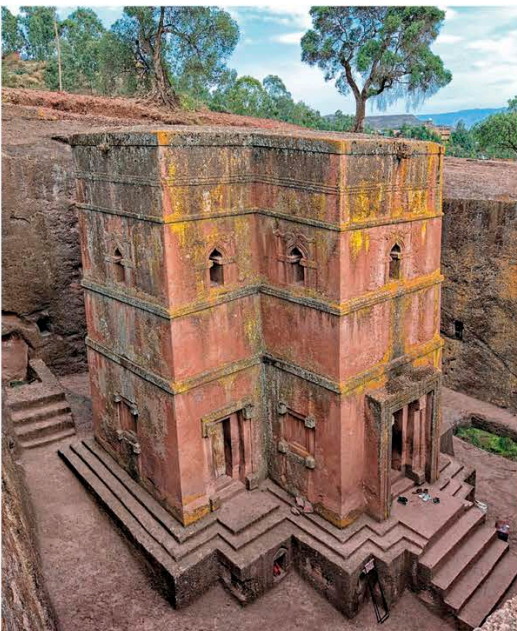
The city of Great Zimbabwe was the capital of the mighty Kingdom of Zimbabwe, which flourished between the 11th and 15th centuries. The city grew rich from the gold trade, and its ruins are some of the oldest and largest in Southern Africa. The impressive Great Enclosure (left) is thought to have been the royal palace.

MANSA MUSA

The Mali Empire reached its height during the reign of Mansa Musa I (reigned 1312–1337) who developed cities such as Timbuktu and transformed the kingdom into an important center of learning. Musa was known for his incredible wealth.



500–1450



▲ ZAGWE DYNASTY

The Christian Zagwe Dynasty ruled northern parts of modern-day Ethiopia and Eritrea between the 12th and 13th centuries. The kingdom was centered around Roba (now called Lalibela in Ethiopia), where they built rock-hewn churches, including the church of Bet Giyorgis (St. George).

FACT

Griots originated in the empire of Mali in the 13th century. They told tales of births, marriages, deaths, and battles and still keep traditions alive today as storytellers, musicians, and oral historians.

▼ MALI EMPIRE

The vast empire of Mali in West Africa was established around 1235. It became famous for the immense wealth of its rulers. The original Great Mosque of Djenné, a symbol of the empire's importance, was allowed to fall into ruin after the fall of the empire in the 17th century. It was rebuilt in 1907.

Djenné's mosque is the world's largest mud-brick structure.

